UMKC Impact & Translation Series

Business Communication Skills for University Researchers

Helping you move your work beyond the university

UMKC research faculty often operate at the forefront of innovation, producing discoveries with the potential to transform industries and address pressing societal needs. Yet, the path from lab bench to practical application requires a skill set rarely emphasized in academic settings - namely, business communication.

UITS Whitepaper

This whitepaper is part of the **UMKC Impact & Translation Series (UITS)** - a set of short videos and supporting materials designed to help faculty think more clearly about how their work can move beyond the university and into real-world use.

The videos introduce core ideas. This document goes deeper on one of those ideas: how to effectively communicate about your innovation.

Business communication plays a direct role in whether research can move beyond the university and into real-world use. It shapes how effectively you engage with funders, industry partners, and other external stakeholders who ultimately determine whether your work advances. Without clear communication, even strong ideas can fail to gain traction. Without effective negotiation, promising opportunities can stall or fall apart. Developing these skills strengthens your ability to move research from discovery into application.

In this guide, we will explore key aspects of communication and negotiation that are essential for UMKC research faculty and graduate students, providing actionable insights to enhance your professional interactions.

Where This Fits in the Translation Process

Moving research beyond the university requires more than a strong idea or technical breakthrough. It requires a series of interactions with people who evaluate that work through a different lens, including funders, industry partners, investors, and potential users. Communication is the mechanism through which those interactions happen.

At each stage of the translation process, researchers are asked to explain what their work does, why it matters, and how it could be used. These moments occur in many forms, from grant proposals and industry conversations to licensing discussions and startup pitches. In each case, the outcome depends not only on the quality of the research, but on how clearly its value can be understood by others.

Negotiation is closely tied to these interactions. Whether discussing funding terms, partnership structures, intellectual property, or roles within a venture, researchers must be able to navigate competing priorities and reach agreements that allow the work to move forward.

These skills are not separate from the translation process. They are part of the infrastructure that supports it. When communication is clear and aligned with the needs of external stakeholders, opportunities advance. When it is not, even strong ideas can stall.

This document focuses on how to approach those interactions more effectively so that your work can move more easily from research into real-world use.

Why Communication and Negotiation Matter

In the context of research translation, communication and negotiation determine whether your work can move forward beyond the university and into real-world use. These skills enable researchers to secure funding, collaborate effectively, and translate scientific discoveries into viable commercial applications.

Strong communication and negotiation abilities empower you to:

- **Secure funding and resources** for research and commercialization efforts.
- **Build productive collaborations** with peers, industry partners, and stakeholders.
- **Effectively translate scientific discoveries** into viable commercial ventures.
- **Navigate business relationships** within academia, industry, and entrepreneurship.

These skills show up at critical moments in the translation process. Whether you are writing a grant proposal, engaging an industry partner, presenting to a potential funder, or negotiating the terms of a collaboration, your ability to communicate clearly and navigate those discussions directly affects whether progress is made.

UMKC provides workshops, mentorship programs, and professional development opportunities designed to help faculty and graduate students refine these essential competencies.

The Role of TLAs (Three-Letter Acronyms) in Business

One of the defining features of business-focused dialogue is the frequent use of **TLAs or Three-Letter Acronyms**, short abbreviations that allow stakeholders to streamline discussions about strategy, finance, and project deliverables. Examples include:

- **ROI** (Return on Investment),
- **IP** (Intellectual Property),
- **KPI** (Key Performance Indicator),
- **TAM** (Total Addressable Market), and
- **CAC** (Customer Acquisition Cost)

Although these acronyms can feel like jargon, they reflect the broader context in which businesses measure success and evaluate opportunities.

For UMKC researchers aiming to commercialize academic innovations, becoming familiar with these abbreviations is not a superficial exercise. Rather, it is a *fundamental step* in learning to frame academic expertise in terms that resonate with corporate sponsors, venture capitalists, and other potential partners. When faculty confidently reference ROI or TAM in a conversation about their technology, they convey an understanding of the commercial imperatives that shape industry decision-making.

Using these terms correctly signals that you understand how external stakeholders evaluate value, risk, and opportunity, which can significantly influence how your work is received.

Securing Funding and Resources

Securing funding is one of the most critical aspects of academic and entrepreneurial success. It is a competitive process that requires a researcher to articulate their work's significance, align proposals with funder priorities, and successfully negotiate agreements.

In many cases, strong research proposals fall short not because of the underlying work, but because the value is not communicated in a way that aligns with how funders or partners make decisions. Misalignment between academic framing and external expectations is a common source of friction that can slow or prevent progress.

To address these expectations, researchers should underscore how their work can generate financial returns, reduce costs, or solve a pressing market need. This approach involves clearly describing the broader environment in which the innovation might operate. Market data—such as potential customer segments, current competitors, and regulatory landscapes—demonstrates that the research isn't just *academically rigorous* but also *commercially promising*.

Communicating your research in a way that resonates with funding agencies, investors, and grant committees requires:

- **Persuasive Writing and Speaking:** Crafting compelling grant proposals, investment pitches, and research presentations that clearly articulate the impact of your work.
- **Audience Awareness:** Tailoring your message to meet the interests and priorities of funding bodies, ensuring they understand the broader implications of your research.
- **Negotiation Tactics:** Successfully negotiating funding terms, budgets, and intellectual property agreements to maximize support for your projects.

An effective proposal or presentation highlights core benefits rather than dwelling solely on technical depth. The language must speak directly to investors, granting bodies, and corporate sponsors by showing them **why** a particular research project is worth financing.

UMKC offers grant writing workshops and faculty development programs through the Office of Research Services to help researchers refine their funding proposals and communication strategies.

Building Collaborative Relationships

Industry collaboration can significantly enhance a research program by bringing real-world expertise, market knowledge, and even financial support to academic endeavors. However, successful partnerships rely on clear, consistent communication. In many cases, corporate partners evaluate a collaboration based on *business-driven priorities* such as product development timelines, competitive advantages, or market readiness.

Effective communication helps you:

- **Align Goals and Expectations:** Clearly define roles and responsibilities within research teams or business partnerships.
- **Prevent and Resolve Conflicts:** Active listening and diplomacy can resolve misunderstandings before they escalate.
- **Ensure Recognition and Fair Contributions:** Negotiating authorship, contributions, and funding allocations fairly enhances long-term partnerships.

When reaching out to potential partners, UMKC researchers are most effective when they provide a succinct but comprehensive explanation of what a partnership could achieve. This explanation should connect the **technical value** of the innovation—whether it's a new manufacturing process or a medical diagnostic technology—to the **business outcomes** that matter most to corporate teams. By framing academic work in terms of cost savings, revenue generation, or brand enhancement, researchers can make it easier for industry partners to see the mutual benefits of collaboration.

Ongoing communication is equally important. Progress reports, virtual meetings, and public-facing updates help ensure that all parties stay aligned and that any emerging challenges or opportunities are promptly addressed. In this regard, adopting industry best practices—such as creating clear milestones and deliverables—fosters trust and encourages future collaboration.

UMKC's Innovation Center and interdisciplinary research groups foster connections between faculty, industry leaders, and entrepreneurs to encourage impactful partnerships.

Transitioning to Entrepreneurship

Some UMKC faculty and graduate students go a step further by launching *their own ventures* to commercialize university-based research. In these scenarios, **business communication** shifts from being an asset to being *absolutely essential*. Founders must navigate pitches for angel investors or venture capitalists, recruit early employees or advisors, and build a brand presence—all of which depend on articulating a compelling story around the innovation.

In entrepreneurship, clarity and conciseness take on added weight. Prospective investors might only give a pitch deck a few minutes of attention before deciding whether to pursue further discussions. Similarly, potential customers need to quickly grasp the value and utility of a new product. Approaching these audiences with concise narratives, well-chosen data points, and a savvy use of TLAs can help a scientific breakthrough stand out in a crowded marketplace.

To effectively move an innovation from the lab to the marketplace, you must:

- **Simplify Complex Information:** Investors and business partners may not have technical expertise; your ability to explain research in clear, compelling language is crucial.
- **Develop a Business Pitch:** Crafting and delivering a strong pitch helps attract funding and industry partners.
- **Negotiate Business Terms:** From equity distribution with co-founders to licensing agreements with corporate partners, negotiation skills play a pivotal role in business success.

Equally important is the ability to adapt messages to a range of audiences. Investors, for instance, may focus on potential return on investment and market size, while customers or end-users are more likely to be interested in cost savings, ease of use, and immediate benefits. By tailoring each conversation to the priorities of the listener, researchers can significantly improve their startup's prospects for success.

Key Communication Skills

When researchers communicate their innovations to potential customers or investors, technical expertise alone is not enough. Success hinges on the ability to translate complex ideas into compelling narratives, foster engagement through active listening, and navigate discussions with emotional intelligence. Below are three essential communication skills that can help researchers make a lasting impact.

Clarity and Conciseness

Technical innovations often involve intricate details, but potential investors and customers may not have the same level of expertise. Researchers must learn to distill complex concepts into clear, concise, and accessible language.

- **Avoid jargon and technical overload** – Use relatable metaphors and real-world applications to illustrate how the innovation works and why it matters.
- **Prioritize key messages** – Focus on the problem the innovation solves, its benefits, and its potential impact, rather than getting lost in technical minutiae.
- **Structure information effectively** – Start with a strong value proposition, provide evidence of viability, and conclude with a clear call to action.

Active Listening

Communication is a two-way process. Understanding the concerns, interests, and feedback of potential investors or customers can refine messaging and build stronger relationships.

- **Listen for key concerns** – Investors may focus on market potential and return on investment, while customers may prioritize ease of use and affordability.
- **Ask clarifying questions** – Engage in meaningful dialogue by seeking to understand their needs, rather than simply presenting information.
- **Adapt based on feedback** – Demonstrating responsiveness to concerns fosters trust and credibility.

Emotional Intelligence

Emotional intelligence (EQ) is critical in high-stakes conversations, helping researchers navigate negotiations, manage differing perspectives, and establish rapport.

- **Read nonverbal cues** – Pay attention to body language and tone of voice to gauge interest or hesitation.
- **Manage emotions effectively** – Stay composed under pressure and respond thoughtfully rather than reactively.
- **Empathize with your audience** – Understanding the motivations and concerns of investors and customers can help tailor messaging in a way that resonates.

Researchers must remember that great communication is not just about conveying information but about making meaningful connections. By mastering clarity, active listening, and emotional intelligence, they can position their innovations for success, foster trust with stakeholders, and ultimately drive commercialization forward.

Essential Negotiation Skills

For researchers seeking to commercialize their innovations, negotiation skills are just as important as technical expertise. Whether discussing funding with investors, licensing agreements with companies, or partnerships with industry leaders, effective negotiation can shape the success of an innovation's journey to market. Below are three essential negotiation skills researchers should develop.

Preparation and Planning

Successful negotiations start well before the conversation begins. Understanding your innovation's value, potential market, and the priorities of the other party sets the stage for productive discussions.

- **Know your numbers** – Be prepared with data on market size, customer demand, development costs, and projected revenue. Investors and partners will expect a solid business case.

- **Define your goals and limits** – Determine your ideal outcomes, acceptable compromises, and absolute deal-breakers in advance.
- **Research the other party** – Understanding the motivations, priorities, and constraints of investors or potential partners allows for more strategic discussions.

Persuasive Communication

How you present your case can significantly influence the outcome of a negotiation. The ability to articulate value and address concerns persuasively is crucial.

- **Lead with benefits, not just features** – Investors care about financial returns, while customers and partners look for real-world benefits. Position your innovation in terms of its impact.
- **Use storytelling** – A compelling narrative about the problem your innovation solves and its potential success can make your pitch more memorable.
- **Demonstrate flexibility** – Being open to alternative deal structures, such as phased investments or milestone-based agreements, can keep negotiations moving forward.

Navigating the Conversation

Negotiations can be high-stakes and sometimes tense. Emotional intelligence helps researchers stay in control, build rapport, and create win-win outcomes.

- **Read the room** – Paying attention to verbal and nonverbal cues can reveal when to push forward and when to step back.
- **Stay calm under pressure** – Investors or partners may test your resolve. Maintaining composure and responding thoughtfully builds credibility.
- **Build relationships, not just transactions** – A collaborative, problem-solving approach often leads to better long-term partnerships than a purely competitive stance.

Negotiation is not about winning or losing—it's about creating mutually beneficial agreements that bring innovations to market successfully. By preparing strategically, communicating persuasively, and leveraging emotional intelligence, researchers can navigate negotiations effectively and secure the resources needed to bring their innovations to life.

Applying These Skills at UMKC

At the University of Missouri-Kansas City (UMKC), researchers have access to a wealth of resources to help them bridge the gap between scientific discovery and commercial success. Effective communication and negotiation skills are critical for translating innovations into real-world impact, securing funding, and forming valuable industry partnerships.

Below are key ways researchers at UMKC can develop and apply these skills before they become essential in their careers.

Participate in Innovation and Entrepreneurship Programs

UMKC offers several programs designed to help researchers sharpen their ability to present, pitch, and negotiate. Engaging in these initiatives provides hands-on experience and direct feedback.

- **Faculty Learning Community: "Talk the Talk: Communicate the Value of Your Innovation"** – This program is specifically designed to help faculty translate research findings into compelling narratives that resonate with investors, industry partners, and customers.
- **Innovation Speaker Series** – Gain firsthand knowledge from entrepreneurs and commercialization experts who have successfully navigated the challenges of funding, licensing, and startup growth.
- **Entrepreneurship Workshops and Pitch Events** – Opportunities such as pitch competitions and commercialization workshops provide structured practice in articulating the value of research to investors and industry leaders.

Guiding Question:

How effectively can you communicate the value of your work to people outside your field, and what would need to improve for that message to lead to real-world use?

Engage the Office of Commercialization and the UMKC Innovation Center

UMKC's Innovation Center and the Office of Commercialization provide faculty with guidance on developing market-ready innovations and negotiating business relationships. Researchers can:

- Schedule **one-on-one commercialization coaching** to refine their messaging and negotiation strategies.
- Learn how to **present innovations to industry partners** through mentorship and structured engagement opportunities.
- Gain experience with **real-world licensing and startup formation processes**, preparing them for future negotiations with investors and corporate partners.

Take Advantage of Mentorship and Networking Opportunities

Strong communication and negotiation skills are best developed through real-world conversations. At UMKC, researchers can:

- **Join interdisciplinary faculty discussion groups** focused on innovation and societal impact, providing a supportive environment to refine messaging.
- **Attend networking events and industry panels** to gain exposure to investor expectations and business negotiation dynamics.

- **Collaborate with the UMKC Innovation Center** to build connections with business leaders, attorneys, and funding sources that can offer insight into effective deal-making strategies.

Practice Skills in Low-Stakes Environment

Waiting until a high-pressure funding pitch or licensing discussion to develop communication and negotiation skills is risky. UMKC provides multiple ways for researchers to practice in a supportive setting:

- **Present research at interdisciplinary faculty meetings** to refine storytelling and audience engagement.
- **Participate in mock negotiations** or case study exercises offered by commercialization programs to experience real-world negotiation dynamics.
- **Leverage OpenScholar** and digital engagement strategies to build visibility and practice articulating research value to non-specialist audiences.

By actively engaging in UMKC's commercialization programs, networking opportunities, and structured practice environments, researchers can develop communication and negotiation skills that will serve them throughout their careers. Whether pitching an innovation, negotiating funding, or securing a licensing deal, these skills will be essential in transforming research into real-world impact.

Conclusion

Effective communication and negotiation are not just supportive skills. They are central to whether research can move beyond the university and into real-world use.

Whether you are securing funding, building partnerships, or exploring a path to commercialization, your ability to communicate the value of your work and navigate key decisions will shape the outcome. These interactions determine whether your work is understood, supported, and ultimately used.

UMKC provides a wealth of resources to help you develop these competencies - take the initiative to refine your abilities and set yourself up for long-term success.

For more information on workshops, mentorship, and commercialization resources, contact UMKC's Office of Commercialization or the UMKC Innovation Center today.

Resources & Contacts

UMKC Office of Commercialization

📍 Website: www.umkcinnovates.com/tech-commercialization

📧 Email: techcomm@umkc.edu

📞 Phone: 816-235-6373